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Portable Coordinate Measuring Arm Joint Design

Mechatronic Project 478
Final Report

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Executive summary

Title of Project
Joint Design for a Portable Coordinate Measuring Arm (PCMA)
Objectives
To derive technical performance measures (TPMs) from an error-propagation model, and use them to design, build, and test a position-holding joint that maintains and /or improves the arm's overall accuracy.
What is current practice and what are its limitations?
Current joints rely on counterbalancing and lack holding torque, meaning the operator must physically support the arm's weight during operation.
What is new in this project?
The introduction of a position-holding mechanism specifically engineered using mathematically derived TPMs.
If the project is successful, how will it make a difference?
It will directly maintain or improve the physical measurement accuracy of the arm. Additionally, it will yield a modified kinematic model to serve as a generalized framework for future accuracy analysis.
What are the risks to the project being a success? Why is it expected to be successful?
Risks: University workshop manufacturing capabilities may fall short of required tolerances, and the holding mechanism could introduce unwanted friction. Expectation of Success: The design requirements are heavily grounded in an established, proven error model.
What contributions have/will other students made/make?
The project builds directly upon an initial error-propagation model developed by Stellenbosch alumna Leon Hall.
Which aspects of the project will carry on after completion and why?
The modified error-propagation model. It will be able to accept custom arm dimensions and compute the uncertainty distribution within a given work volume, forming the mathematical foundation for future PCMA development.
What arrangements have been/will be made to expedite continuation?

Extensive, standardized documentation will be left behind to ensure future researchers can build directly onto this work without repeating groundwork.

ECSA Exit Level Outcomes

This section addresses the following Engineering Council of South Africa (ECSA) exit level outcomes and indicates how each outcome was demonstrated in the project.

GA 1 - Problem-Solving

The project addresses an engineering problem, which is the lack of a joint design for PCMA's that meet accuracy requirements that account for spatial dependency and proper position-holding implementation without the impedance of uninhibited movement.

GA 2 - Application Scientific and Engineering Knowledge

GA 3 - Engineering Design

GA 5 - Use of Engineering Tools

GA 6 - Professional and Technical Communication

GA 8 - Individual and Collaborative Teamwork

GA 9 - Independent Learning Ability

Acknowledgements

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List of symbols

Constants

$L_0 =$ 300 mm

Variables

Re_D	Reynolds number (diameter)	[]
x	Coordinate	[m]
$\ddot{x}$	Acceleration	[m/s ²]
θ	Rotation angle	[rad]
τ	Moment	[N·m]

Vectors and Tensors

$\vec{v}$ Physical vector, see equation ...

Subscripts

a	Adiabatic
a	Coordinate

Abbreviations

3D	three-dimensional
AI	artificial intelligence
CAD	computer-aided design
D-H	Denavit-Hartenberg
FEA	Finite Element Analysis
PCMA	portable coordinate measuring arm
SPAT	single-point articulation test

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

A portable coordinate measuring arm (PCMA) is a handheld metrology instrument that captures three-dimensional (3D) coordinates directly from a physical object, as shown in 1.1 below, (1).



Figure 1.1: A portable coordinate measurement arm, (1)

PCMA's offer adaptable measurement systems for multiple applications, such as dimensional analysis, computer-aided design (CAD) inspection, reverse engineering, etc., (2). The main limitation of PCMA's is the effect of manual operation, which can introduce positional instability and dynamic structural deformation during measurement, (3). Manual operation can also inhibit calibration procedures as it is required that the PCMA must be held still during the procedure, (4).

As a result, designing an effective joint with a position-holding mechanism would improve the design of a PCMA and a good practice of safety. By designing the joint in this manner, error due to manual operation will be minimised, kinematic stability and accuracy will be improved.

1.2 Aim and Objectives

The aim of this project is to implement a position-holding mechanism on a PCMA without jeopardising its accuracy and ease of movement.

The objectives of the project are:

1. To generalise the conventional Denavit-Hartenberg(D-H) model derived by Hall and Schreve by sampling the working volume of a PCMA determining distribution of uncertainty along its length, (5).
2. To design, build, and test the joint design through the single-point articulation test (SPAT), such that it maintains and/or improves the accuracy of the PCMA.
3. To compare the results from SPAT to the D-H model and verify the joint design's effect on the PCMA's accuracy.

1.3 Scope

In the process of determining D-H parameters, operation manual and available schematics will be used. In addition, only joint will be designed, built, and tested for data acquisition, through calibration and accuracy testing via SPAT.

1.4 Motivation

PCMA's are becoming more popular than tradition coordinate measuring machines (CMM) for in-line¹ and on-site industrial measurement, (1). They have broad applicability across multiple industries such as aerospace, automotive, heavy manufacturing, where having a portable measurement instrument decreases handling time, production delays, and revision of work.

Despite their growing popularity, the PCMA's revolute joints must satisfy competing demands, including:

- Tight run-out tolerances for spatial accuracy.
- Sufficient holding torque to keep the arm stationary once released.
- Internal cable routing.

This has proved difficult since there are found commercial available joints that meet these demands. In addition, it has been established that angular position errors at each joint propagate through the kinematic chain, which affects end-effector's

¹In the context of PCMA's, "in-line" refers to performing quality inspections and measurements directly on the production shop floor, instead of a temperature-controlled quality laboratory, (1).

accuracy, proving that joints have a measurable impact on the PCMA's accuracy, (6). This project addresses the gap by deriving a joint specifications from a generalised model based off of an error model that was developed by a Stellenbosch Alumnus, Leon Hall, (5). This will produce a validated joint and testing methodology to support future PCMA development.

1.5 Use of AI Tools

Gemini is an artificial intelligence (AI) tool will be used check grammatical errors and sentence structure as well as LaTeX formatting for the report.

1.6 Report Overview

This section follows the following structure:

- Section 1 introduces the project background, aim and objectives, scope, and motivation for project.
- Section 2 presents a literature review discussing sources relevant to PCMA joint design, position-holding technology, kinematic modeling, error analysis, and PCMA testing.
- Section 3 details the PCMA's requirement analysis.

Chapter 2

Literature review

2.1 PCMA Context

Sources such as Leussink Engineering and Meagher gave context as what PCMA's are and how they are used.

2.2 The Denavit-Hartenberg Model

Chapter 3

Requirement Analysis

The objective of the requirement analysis is to establish clear expectations of the PCMA's joint design for the purposes of concept development.

3.1 Identification of Stakeholders

The first step in the requirement analysis process is to identify stakeholders from the operational and support life cycle phases of the project. Stakeholders will be classified into the following categories, as defined below:

- Primary stakeholders directly interact with the system while it is in operation.
- Secondary stakeholders contribute to the development and functioning of the system.
- Indirect stakeholders rely on or are affected by the system, but do not interact with the system directly.

The stakeholders relevant to the project are defined in Table 3.1 below.

Table 3.1: Identified stakeholders and their classifications

Stakeholder ID	Description	Classification
SID_01	Supervisor of the project	Primary
SID_02	Students researching PCMA development	Secondary
SID_03	Companies invested in PCMA development	Indirect
SID_04	Mechanical workshop staff	Indirect
SID_05	Mechatronics laboratory managers	Indirect

3.2 System Context

The next step is

Chapter 4

Conclusions

Appendix A

Mathematical proofs

A.1 Euler's equation

Euler's equation gives the relationship between the trigonometric functions and the complex exponential function.

$$e^{i\theta} = \cos \theta + i \sin \theta \quad (\text{A.1})$$

Inserting $\theta = \pi$ in (A.1) results in Euler's identity

$$e^{i\pi} + 1 = 0 \quad (\text{A.2})$$

A.2 Navier Stokes equation

The Navier–Stokes equations mathematically express momentum balance and conservation of mass for Newtonian fluids. Navier-Stokes equations using tensor notation:

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} [\rho u_j] = 0 \quad (\text{A.3a})$$

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} (\rho u_i) + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} [\rho u_i u_j + p \delta_{ij} - \tau_{ji}] = 0, \quad i = 1, 2, 3 \quad (\text{A.3b})$$

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} (\rho e_0) + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} [\rho u_j e_0 + u_j p + q_j - u_i \tau_{ij}] = 0 \quad (\text{A.3c})$$

Appendix B

Experimental results

List of references

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